

DEVSECOPS & PLATFORM · ISSUE 06 OF 08

SLIs, SLOs and error budgets.

An SLO is a decision tool for when to slow down.

006

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Three terms

TERM	MEANING	EXAMPLE
SLI	What you measure	% requests under 300ms
SLO	Your internal target	99.9% over 30 days
SLA	Contract with penalties	99.5% or credits



Error budget over 30 days

7.2 h

at 99%

43 min

at 99.9%

4.3 min

at 99.99%

Each extra nine cuts the budget by 10x. Price that in before promising it.



Burn-rate alerts

BUDGET SPENT	WINDOW	ACTION
2%	1 hour	Page
5%	6 hours	Page
10%	3 days	Ticket



Error budget policy

01 Budget left

Ship features at normal pace.

02 Budget low

Extra review on risky changes.

03 Budget gone

Freeze risky releases, prioritise reliability.

04 Agreed in advance

With product, before the incident.



SLO habits

DO

- ✓ SLOs on user journeys
- ✓ Alert on burn rate
- ✓ Review targets quarterly

AVOID

- ✗ 100% targets
- ✗ SLOs on CPU usage
- ✗ Alert on every error spike

KEY TAKEAWAY

Measure what users feel, then let the budget decide the pace.

- SLI measures, SLO targets, SLA contracts
- Alert on burn rate
- Agree the budget policy upfront

YOUR TURN

Does your team have an error budget policy that anyone actually follows?

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